tion of dance, further enriching the overall experience. At the Mudra dance festival, they are showcasing various classical forms with their distinctive aharya elements—the Kuchipudi *thala* plate, the distinctive *veni* (plait) used in certain dance forms, and even modern interpretations in Bollywood like Kathak danseuse Saswati Sen's work, where she performs to iconic songs choreographed by Pt Birju Maharaj from movies like *Shatranj Ke Khiladi* and *Devdas*. While you may have missed performances by Kuchipudi dancer Vyjayanthi Kashi & her troupe or *Eka Prashna*, an Odissi presentation by Dr Aruna Mohanty & troupe, portraying the voices of mythical women seeking answers, you can still plan to see the Rangasri Little Ballet Troupe's *The Ramayana – A Dance Drama in Puppet Style*, a visually striking retelling using stylised masks and human puppetry. Or *Beeja—Earth Seed*, an evocative Bharatanatyam production by Padma Shri Malavika Sarukkai, which contemplates humanity's impact on the planet.

Do festivals like this make classical dance relatable to contemporary audiences? Dasgupta responds, "There's a conception that classical dance needs modernisation to be relatable, but I disagree. These art forms speak to our everyday lives, spirituality and personal growth. We make specific efforts to explain elements like shlokas or particular messages to audiences. Our post-performance discussions with renowned artistes explore deeper aspects of each theme."

"As a community, we must encourage attendance at these performances. The more we value our cultural heritage, the more we ensure it thrives for future generations," she concludes. ■

–Priya Pathiyan





OF PAST STRUGGLES Clockwise from left, Hans-Joachim Lietsche, Abhiroop Banerjee and the Brandenburg Gate in the '70s

DOCUMENTARY

PRISON DIARIES

***Abhiroop Banerjee**'s first documentary,* Beyond the Berlin Wall, *featuring interviews with Stasi prisoners, has bagged a major award*



Kolkata-born Abhiroop Banerjee has yet to finish his bachelor's degree in film, and he has become the recipient of a top award at the Berlin Independent Film Festival. In February, his documentary, *Beyond the Berlin Wall–Reports from Stasi Prisoners*, won the Best Documentary Feature award at the festival's 2025 edition. Banerjee shares it with his co-directors Berglind Sóley Elstermann Jansdóttir, Marcela Faganello Galluzzi and Matthias Leupold.

The 61-minute film features interviews with three former political prisoners, who look back on their memories of subjugation in the hands of the Stasi, the state security of Communist East Germany, and their imprisonment at the then Stasi prison, the Hohenschönhausen Interrogation Centre. The interviewees include Leupold, who was a driver for a fashion magazine at the time, as well as former television journalist Edda Schönherz and former window dresser Hans-Joachim (Akki) Lietsche.

Other than the interviews, the documentary **IS PACKED WITH ARCHIVAL** photos of East Germany

Leupold is Banerjee's professor at his film school in Berlin, and often conducts guided tours at the Hohenschönhausen, which is now a memorial centre. "I was introduced to the prison when he arranged a tour for my class, and that is also how the idea of the documentary originated," says Banerjee. "I had a vague idea about the GDR and what the Berlin Wall stood for, but visiting the prison and making the documentary made it more real." Besides the interviews, the documentary is packed with archival photographs of East Germany.

For Banerjee, the filmmaking experience was an eye-opener. "There's a difference between reading about something in a textbook and listening to someone share their experience," he says. Leupold's presence helped Banerjee get access to the prison. "We shot the three interviews in three days, for around two hours for each. But we did come back to shoot some B-rolls after we had started editing, which was a long process of deciding what to keep and what to leave out."

"Surreal" is what Banerjee says is the experience of winning a top film festival award, that too for his "first film of any kind, one I have been a part of from beginning to end". He hopes to move into fiction soon. As for returning to his homeland, he is ecstatic: "I really, really want to make films in India." ■

–Devarsi Ghosh